

The Union Institute Graduate School
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Seminar: "Research Methodology: Phenomenology, Hermeneutics, and
Heuristics"
Royal Sonesta Hotel
Cambridge, MA
Convener: Bruce C. Douglass
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Seminar Evaluation

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REVIEW

This seminar was portrayed, both by title, and in the syllabus, as an intellectual examination of three distinct research approaches to the understanding of human experience in various contexts. These approaches — phenomenology, hermeneutics, and heuristics — incorporate techniques that in varying degree, are generally lumped together under the umbrella of *qualitative research*, although many scholars would vehemently argue against the inclusion of heuristics under that banner, and many others would argue against the inclusion of heuristics as a viable research approach under any banner whatsoever.

The syllabus describes the seminar as examining the distinction of "hermeneutic phenomenology" from "structural phenomenology," drawing from the works of Gadamer and Ricoeur, and in a letter from the convener, the importance of the required readings by Giorgi, Moustakas, Patton and Van Manen are stressed for the required orientation in the position of "descriptive methodologies" within the larger context of qualitative research and in the dialog within the philosophy of science. The letter further mentions an article by Giorgi included in the seminar packet that discusses important methodological considerations, and urges that it be read carefully (Douglass 1996). The recommended readings in the syllabus include many of the leading names in the historical formulation of methodology in the human sciences, including Husserl, Polanyi, Gadamer, Ricoeur, and Van Kaam, but curiously, relegates these main works — especially the seminal works of Gadamer and Ricoeur, from which the syllabus claims the main discussions on the definitions of descriptive methodology and phenomenological approaches are

drawn — to *recommended* rather than *required* readings (ibid.). This begs the question, “How can a meaningful discussion and presentation be conducted, when the source material upon which the discussion is based has not been reviewed and studied equally by all the participants?”

While at first blush, the seminar syllabus itself seemed to promise an interesting and intellectual presentation and discussion in an area of scholarly interest to me, I had too casually dismissed telltale signs that ominously suggested otherwise. In both the letter from the convener and in the syllabus, all three research approaches were branded as *descriptive*, but hermeneutics is unequivocally *interpretive*. “The phenomenological (descriptive) approach focuses on the structures of experience, the organizing principles that give form and meaning to the lifeworld, while the hermeneutic (interpretive) approach concentrates on the historical meaning of experience and its developmental and cumulative effects at both the individual and social levels” (Polkinghorne 1983, 203). In fact, in the article by Giorgi included in the seminar packet and stressed by the convener as discussing important methodological considerations, Giorgi states, “. . . I shall argue for a descriptive logic for scientific knowledge in the human sciences rather than for an *interpretive or hermeneutic approach*” [emphasis mine] (Giorgi 1992, 119). In another required work on the reading list, Patton says, “. . . a phenomenological study . . . is one that focuses on *descriptions* [emphasis mine] of what people experience and how it is that they experience what they experience” (Patton 1990, 71); whereas, “Hermeneutic philosophy, developed by Wilhelm Dilthey and other German philosophers, is the study of *interpretive* [emphasis mine] understanding, or meaning, with special attention to context and original purpose” (ibid., 84). Patton goes on to list the four principles that Kneller defined for hermeneutic inquiry, as follows:

1. Understanding a human act or product, and hence all learning, is like interpreting a text.
2. All interpretation occurs within a tradition
3. Interpretation involves opening myself to a text (or its analogue) and questioning it.
4. I must interpret a text in the light of my situation. (ibid., 84-85)

Sadly, and pathetically, these are only two of example after example in which the convener seems to be totally estranged from the details of the works he himself selected for the reading list. He refers to the seminar subject as “descriptive methodologies” and he even uses the term, *hermeneutic phenomenology*, as if it were a discrete approach, combining two mutually exclusive approaches as a single synthesized research method!

While in fact, hermeneutics and phenomenology may often complement each other in a full research study design, the fact remains that they are separate, distinct methodological approaches. “Interpreting the meaning of a particular conversation (*parole*) often requires knowledge of the structure of the language (*la langue*) in which the conversation is taking place. Descriptive and hermeneutic methods supplement each other, the first focusing beneath the surface of individual events in order to describe patterns, the second focusing on the linguistic and nonlinguistic actions in order to penetrate to the meaning of these events” (Polkinghorne 1983, 214). While we can, in fact, talk about a *hermeneutical-phenomenological psychology*, in which we mean a study in human sciences that incorporates both a descriptive stage (i.e., phenomenological psychology approach) and an interpretive stage (i.e., hermeneutic approach) to evaluate a research question, this does not mean that the two approaches are somehow amalgamated into a single integrated approach, but that a particular study uses both approaches to evaluate the data, in the same way that the much-cited empirical-phenomenological *Duquesne Studies* conducted over a twenty-year period at Duquesne University used widely disparate empirical and phenomenological methodology to evaluate the same data to yield a fuller understanding of the results. It is clear that the convener has failed to 1) appreciate the significant distinction between a phenomenological and a hermeneutic approach, and 2) fails to grasp the significance of the difference between a discrete dual-approach study and the methodological divergence of the two disparate research approaches embodied within the study.

Both in the syllabus and the “seminar” itself (a significant amount of forbearance is needed to term the event in question a “seminar”) there is a hopeless confusion between the *philosophy* of phenomenology and the *practice* of phenomenology as a research method. In particular, the significance of the difference between philosophical phenomenology and phenomenological psychology is altogether obfuscated into a hodgepodge of contradictory and confusing babble. Many of the writings and concepts related to phenomenological philosophy are used by the convener to explain a research technique in phenomenological psychology. The issue is not simply a cavil over semantic nuance, but a fundamental misconception of research techniques and approach strategy. This is why an explanation of a technique in the seminar often seemed to have no relation whatsoever to a research strategy or methodology. “The difference between phenomenological philosophy and phenomenological psychology has to do with the two different bracketings or reductions. Under the philosophical or transcendental reduction, both the object pole (world) and the subject pole (consciousness) are derealized or bracketed In the case of the psychological phenomenological bracketing, we bracket the object pole (we put its reality status into suspension), but we leave the psychological ego exactly as it is in the

world. We do not suspend its particularities because this is what we wish to study. We are interested in this situated ego which has desires and fears. The psychological phenomenological reduction takes us out of the natural attitude by subsuming the object under subjectivity (object-as-meant) and leaves us with a situated consciousness intending meanings. From Husserl's standpoint (which claims the validity of a transcendental ego), we as phenomenological psychologists must admit the paradox: The 'I' which we study (the 'myself') which constitutes the world is also itself situated in the world. It is both *constituting* and *constituted*. We find no difficulty in accepting this premise because our interests are not philosophical. For our purposes, we need only to discover the meanings which are intended by the situated ego in their psychological significations" (Bullington and Karlsson 1984, 56).

In addition to this very basic confusion, which has profound implications for the concepts and strategies of a research approach, no consideration is given to several other fields of research associated with a phenomenological perspective, each with significantly different viewpoints and objectives. Included in this group are phenomenological sociology, ethnomethodology, and existential-phenomenology. All of these involve techniques and methods for describing the structures and patterns in human experience, but there was no mention of any of these fields or the concepts, techniques, and methods which distinguish them; everything was not only lumped together as "phenomenology," but even more ludicrous, as "hermeneutic phenomenology."

It is true that Heidegger, Gadamer and Ricoeur thought a strong affinity existed between phenomenology and hermeneutics. In the *Conflict of Interpretations*, Ricoeur discusses the concept of a *hermeneutic phenomenology*, whereby he sought to graft hermeneutics to a phenomenological philosophy, in which he uses phenomenology as a version of a comparativist strategy and as a means of recovering the intentionalities of symbolic expressions (that is, discovering the underlying experiential significations of those expressions) in working out the methodological grounds for a theory of analogous meaning (Ricoeur 1974). But isn't this simply the use of phenomenology to arrive at a set of constructs that inform hermeneutical research, much like the use of empirical methods to inform phenomenological research in the *Duquesne Studies*? In *Hermeneutics & The Human Sciences*, Ricoeur discusses the relationship between phenomenology and hermeneutics in the form of a debate, confronting the question of what has remained of phenomenology in the aftermath of the devastating critique of same by Heidegger and Gadamer. Ricoeur makes an important distinction between the form of idealistic phenomenology advanced by Husserl, and phenomenology as a general perspective from which human experience can be understood, using the concept of intentionality as a means of describing and studying that experience (Ricoeur 1982). Ricoeur does not actually use the word *intentionality*, instead

embodying the concept in the word *intentionality*, which is also used to represent the concept of *intentional object*. Husserl, Heidegger, and later, the existential phenomenologists, clearly differentiate between *intensional* and *intentional*. This differentiation is a fundamentally important one, allowing a description of the structures of the perceptions not only of the object of consciousness or thought (intentionality), but also of the perceptions of relationships (social, physical, poetic or aesthetic, emotional, etc) of that what is understood or assumed, or not understood or not assumed, about the intentional object (intensionality). Without clearly seeing both structures, we cannot describe the real essence of an experience.

Ricoeur concludes that it is really the form of idealistic phenomenology advanced by Husserl that succumbs to the hermeneutical critique of Heidegger and Gadamer, not phenomenology as such, and once this form is renounced, a convincing argument can be made for a deep and mutual affinity between hermeneutics and phenomenology (Ricoeur 1982). As John B. Thompson (ed. and trans.) points out, Ricoeur shows that, “. . . hermeneutics shares with phenomenology both the assumption that the question of meaning is primary, and the thesis that the source of meaning is anterior to language [and determines that] the method of phenomenology is ineluctably interpretive . . .” (ibid., 21). It must be emphasized here, however, that Ricoeur is engaging in a *philosophical* discourse, and like Gadamer, does not extend such philosophical discourse to explicit research methodologies under the rubric of phenomenology or hermeneutics. There is a very distinct divide between philosophy and practical applied research. As Thompson states, “The essays collected in this volume are part of a philosophical evolution which they both express and continue. As an expression of this evolution, the essays recover and refine many of the ideas which have emerged in the course of Ricoeur’s career Ricoeur’s method is now explicitly hermeneutical, marking a shift away from the phenomenological emphasis of his earlier work The reader of the essays presented here will discover a philosophy, which, in spite of its declared allegiances, is genuinely open. Ricoeur’s ideas do not form a closed system. His thought is not constrained by the dictates of an orthodox position or by the boundaries of an established discipline. His work is informed by the contributions of many intellectual traditions, from hermeneutics and phenomenology, to analytical philosophy, structuralism and critical theory; and these contributions are moulded into a perspective which is original and unique” (ibid., 25-26).

Hermeneutics and phenomenology are clearly separated in terms of applied research methodology and approach, maintaining a strict dichotomy of interpretation and description in actual practice. Like Ricoeur, Gadamer was concerned with a philosophical position rather than a practical approach.

“Gadamer’s concern was not to develop a method for the human sciences in the way that both Schleiermacher and Dilthey had wanted to do. He wanted to clarify the conditions under which all understanding actually occurs. He did not want to replace methodological investigations, but he did want to explore the underlying dimensions in which interpretation takes place” (Polkinghorne 1983, 227-228). Also like Ricoeur and Heidegger, Gadamer viewed phenomenology, as well as *all inquiry*, as essentially interpretive. “He [Gadamer] took from Heidegger the basic assumption that all human knowledge is ultimately interpretation because it is derived from a historical and cultural perspective” (ibid., 228). But this does not in any way suggest that descriptive (phenomenological) and interpretive (hermeneutic) techniques are identical in kind and interchangeable; in terms of actual research methodologies, there remains a sharp delineation between the interpretive approach and the descriptive approach. Though all human inquiry can be seen in the broad sense as interpretive, in the narrow sense, there are very definitive descriptive means elucidating the nature of an experience through the exacting identification of the structures and patterns that form that experience, just as there are very definitive means by which an action or experience may be analysed with respect to its underlying meaning, both to the subject and the researcher, and interpreted within a given context. The convener fails to understand this fundamental distinction, and as a consequence, totally misses the underlying principles and teleology of the various techniques and methods employed in the descriptive and interpretive research approaches. The convener is unable to place the various research techniques in the proper perspective and misrepresents their actual application.

The hopeless confusion of the convener is vividly revealed in the first sentence of the third paragraph from the top of the first page of the seminar syllabus, which reads, “Hermeneutic phenomenology will be distinguished from structural phenomenology, with emphasis on the hermeneutic circle, problems of language and interpretation, and the place of symbol in understanding, drawing particularly from the works of Gadamer and Ricoeur” (Douglass 1996). This sentence mixes up hermeneutics, philosophical hermeneutics, existential-phenomenology, structuralism, symbolic interactionism, and ethnomethodology, to name a few traditions being alluded to. The sentence is patently ridiculous. We have already discussed the confusion between hermeneutics and phenomenology. While a discussion on the similarities and differences between all the other research traditions mentioned above are beyond the scope of this evaluation, the previous discussions on the confusion between phenomenological philosophy and phenomenological psychology, between phenomenology and hermeneutics, and between philosophical discourse and applied research methodology, should be sufficient to register a red flag of real significance.

We have rebutted the legitimacy of the term *hermeneutic phenomenology* as a discrete research methodology, but another term, *structural phenomenology*, is equally problematic. Rather than labor long on this issue, I would simply like to make a couple of brief points. While phenomenology focuses on revealing the structure and patterns of human experience, and the major names in the development of phenomenology, from Husserl, Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty, Richard Zaner, Eugène Minkowski, V. E. von Gebattel, Ernest Keen, Alfred Schutz, to Amedeo Giorgi and others, have talked about the *structures of experience*, and have developed detailed structural definitions, and many have been heavily influenced by, and have incorporated concepts from, structuralism, phenomenology is inherently incongruent with structuralism.

Structuralism, as defined initially by Ferdinand de Saussure, and refined specifically for different fields of study by such intellectual luminaries as Leonard Bloomfield, Claude Lévi-Strauss, Edmund Leach, Mary Douglas, Roland Barthes, Louis Althusser, Louis Hjelmslev, and others, examines the individual elements or structures of a phenomenon, analysing the interrelationships of those structures strictly as discrete components rather than as artifacts of a greater whole (i.e., within a closed and autonomous system of internal dependencies), and in the case of Straussian structuralism in anthropology, as elements in binary opposition upon which basic contrasts a cultural system evolves. Since structuralism is ahistorical and deterministic, disregarding the active role of the individual in creating cultural patterns and totally dismissive of human creative activity, it is antithetical to phenomenology whose object of study is exactly that human action and experience that is ignored in structuralism.

Structuralism is in fact more closely aligned with hermeneutics, both being concerned with analysis of the relationship of component parts and both originating from a rhetorical tradition (structuralism from linguistics and hermeneutics from literature). In the *Conflict of Interpretations*, Ricoeur provides a comprehensive discourse on structuralism and hermeneutics, concluding that structural comprehension is never without a degree of hermeneutic comprehension (Ricoeur 1974), hence, instead of structural phenomenology, one may, with more legitimacy, refer to the concept of structural hermeneutics, though, strictly speaking, this too is not without its problems, as the historical view and intentionality of the author of the action or text under study so important for a hermeneutical evaluation is denied in the traditional boundaries of structuralism.

From these discussions and the confusion of the convener, we can conclude that there is a large gap between the philosophical dialog upon which the techniques and methods of the phenomenological and hermeneutic research approaches

were derived and the evolution of the relevant methodologies. This gap is the source of the confusion between the philosophy and the practice, and is evident in the reading list which fails to include works which either discuss the evolution of specific applied methodologies and techniques or provide detailed tutorial exposition of the methods and techniques employed in actual research practice.

The Patton book (Patton 1990), while ostensibly a guide to such practice and research procedures, is nothing more than a very superficial review of the methods and their philosophical bases. *Phenomenology and Psychological Research* (Giorgi 1985b) does a good job in elucidating various techniques in phenomenological psychology through actual case studies, but does not provide any framework in which studies are carried out, ignoring such essentials as the scope and boundary of a study; the mechanics and concerns of a research design; the relationship between research question, research subjects, nature of target data and data collection methodology and analytical methodology; demonstrability of results, validity controls; etc. The book is really more theoretically orientated, discussing the nature of the application of phenomenological psychology, but without a detailed exposition of *how* studies are actually conducted, although the last case study in the book provides a narrow glimpse into the research outline and design. There is absolutely nothing in the syllabus reading list (Douglass 1996) concerned with the application of hermeneutic methods and techniques.

Up to this point, I have purposefully omitted *heuristic* inquiry in this evaluation for the simple reason that many, if not most, qualitative researchers do not consider such an approach viable, or at least, an approach that belongs under the mantle of qualitative research. In *Methodology for the Human Sciences*, Donald Polkinghorne's esteemed, encyclopedic text on the origins, history and evolution of qualitative systems of inquiry, no mention of any kind is made of *heuristic* inquiry. The same may also be said for Judith Meloy's *Writing the Qualitative Dissertation*, and in fact, for all the works on the reading list and the entire contents of Dr. Sigman's seminar (Sigman 1996) on qualitative research held just prior to the current seminar under review.

Although *heuristic* inquiry is stated to be a derivative of phenomenology and, as described by Patton, "focuses on intense human experiences" (Patton 1990, 71) and therefore would seem to lend itself most readily to the study of the experience of highly emotive or traumatic states in psychological research, or certainly phenomenological psychological research, it is conspicuous by its absence in Bullington and Karlsson's article "Introduction to Phenomenological Psychological Research" (1980) in the book *Phenomenology and Psychological Research* (Giorgi 1985b) and in similar reviews of the techniques, methods and approaches in phenomenological psychology. Even in the exceedingly

comprehensive bound reading packet for the Union Institute seminar “Practical Research: Planning and Design I,” convened by George Taylor and Michael Trumbull, the only discussion of *heuristic* inquiry appears in two or three very short articles by Union Institute affiliates — there is simply no reference to *heuristic* research or inquiry outside of the Union Institute clique. All authors whose works are cited as heuristic studies in Patton’s book; i.e., E. Craig, S. Hawka, E. Weidman, L. Katz, V. Cheyne, and R. Marino, are all Union Institute graduates whose cited works are Union Institute dissertations, with the sole exception of E. Craig. Though Craig’s cited work was a Boston University dissertation, Craig was a long-standing student of, and collaborator with, Clark Moustakas, the originator of “heuristic inquiry.” Moustakas received his Ph.D. from the Union Institute, where he is now a core faculty member of the Graduate School.

Heuristic research, as defined in the context of this seminar under review, is the sole invention of Clark Moustakas, who, along with Michael Patton (a core faculty member of The Union Institute Graduate School) and I suppose, by virtue of association, the convener of this seminar under review (a core faculty member of UIGS and coauthor with Moustakas of a paper on *heuristics*), are perceived as the *wunderkinder* of The Union Institute, bearing the banner MOST LOFTY AND INFALLIBLE FACULTY. All of the literature cited by both Moustakas (1990) and Patton (1990) directly related to heuristic research are by individuals with some affiliation with the Union Institute and/or Moustakas (most works cited are Union Institute doctoral dissertations, the remainder are dissertations and papers from former students of Moustakas at the Merrill-Palmer Institute, Saybrook Institute, or the Center for Humanistic Studies). The *heuristic* approach, then, as used at The Union Institute, is far from a common, universally accepted method of qualitative research.

Not wishing to discuss the merits of Moustakas’ heuristics, or lack thereof, as a technique or method of any real value, since I address this issue as well as the issue of the merits of qualitative research in general, and other issues related to scientific research and critical thinking in a forthcoming paper, I find it very disturbing the way this seminar in particular, and the Union clique in general has attempted to portray Moustakas’ heuristics as a legitimate, mainstream research method. I say *Moustakas’ heuristics* because heuristics refers to several well-known and accepted problem-solving techniques that have absolutely nothing to do with the narrow and esoteric meaning that Moustakas has created. In pedagogy, heuristics refers to “an educational method in which learning takes place through discoveries that result from investigations made by the student” (*American Heritage Electronic Dictionary*, 3rd ed. Houghton Mifflin, 1992) In general problem solving, heuristics refers to “a usually speculative formulation

serving as a guide in the investigation or solution of a problem;” for example, use of a heuristic device such as “ideal type” in historiography to interpret or understand different actions and events of historical significance (ibid.). In computer science, heuristics refers to “a problem-solving technique in which the most appropriate solution of several found by alternative methods is selected at successive stages of a program for use in the next step of the program” (ibid.). This technique in computer programming has been extrapolated to statistics as a mathematical procedure used to analyze various types of data.

It seems to me, that the appropriation of the word *heuristic*, a well-known term representing accepted problem-solving techniques in wide use throughout various disciplines and mainstream research, is not very dissimilar from the nefarious practice of unscrupulous marketeers naming and packaging an inferior product so that it might be confused with a popular product of higher quality, creating sales volume by mistaken identity with the virtues of a superior product, offering dubious virtue on its own. I myself was confused by the term *heuristic*, expecting to learn about a traditional problem-solving technique in mainstream research that is being creatively applied within a recognized qualitative research paradigm. Such could not be further from the truth. What I discovered to my chagrin, was a highly questionable “approach” created by a individual totally outside the field and the ongoing dialog in the philosophy of science and used only by that individual and a handful of colleagues and students within a small clique.

Indeed, I feel extremely confident in saying that virtually no scholar in qualitative research outside The Union Institute circle of affiliation or connection is even remotely familiar with either the usage of the term *heuristic* as a method of qualitative research or human science inquiry, or the approach itself as defined by Moustakas, under any appellation whatsoever. In fact, curious to see how Moustakas’ work is cataloged by RLIN (Research Libraries Information Network), a major database of library holdings in the U.S. that critically assigns subject headings based on its own internal criterion, I checked the book *Heuristic Research* (1990) under RLIN, and found that the work was cataloged under the subject “problem solving,” the dictionary definition of “heuristic,” not Moustakas’ definition! Because of such a blatant misuse of an established term, RLIN ignored the author’s category of his own work! Moustakas’ book, *Loneliness* (1961), was simply cataloged under the subject “loneliness,” rather than as a heuristic qualitative research inquiry into loneliness or a phenomenological study of loneliness. There does not appear to be any acceptance of either Moustakas’ esoteric meaning of “heuristic” or his esoteric method of inquiry anywhere outside of the Union Institute frame of reference.

Since the inception of Moustakas' heuristics by Moustakas as a formalized technique in the early 1960's, almost 40 years ago, the total corpus of direct studies in Moustakas' heuristic research is no more than about 20 or so works, if that. It is a disservice to unsuspecting students to hawk Moustakas' heuristics as an accepted research technique by misappropriation of the traditional, established term and by failing to be absolutely clear and up front that the term is being applied very narrowly and arbitrarily — totally unrelated to the accepted meaning — to a highly questionable technique that has yet to win any support of note outside its own very narrow self-promoting clique.

Why not call this technique something like “introspective dialog” or “empathetic coresearch” or “focused indwelling and experiential empathy,” etc. that seems to more accurately define the nature and practice of the technique? Whether I agree or disagree with the usefulness of the technique, I would have no criticism whatsoever were it presented in an open up-front manner, with an original, descriptive appellation and an initial qualifying statement that it is the sole invention of Clark Moustakas — perhaps elaborated on over the years by his colleagues and students — that has failed to gain notable support and recognition outside his immediate circle, but that it is believed (by the Moustakas circle) to have value and particular merit in some research questions for the reasons to be presented. Students may then evaluate it on those terms and make up their own minds as to its viability. Presenting this technique as an established, recognized research method is highly misleading and potentially harmful to the student, who may elect to do a Moustakas' heuristic dissertation, only to find that her/his work is not accepted by mainstream academia or within the student's particular field. Even if the student does not elect to do a dissertation using Moustakas' heuristic method, the student is mistakenly led to believe that the term *heuristic* applies specifically to Moustakas' method, and/or that method is generally recognized and accepted within the field of qualitative research and phenomenology. It seems to me no accident that the well-established term *heuristic* was misappropriated to give Moustakas' method an aura of legitimacy it would not otherwise have. If I am mistaken in that impression, I remain unapologetic since surely the confusion cannot fail to be recognized by Moustakas et al., and, as we see, rather than making any attempt to rectify any chance of confusion, they are quite happy in exploiting it to the fullest.

In barely skimming the surface of the concepts and tenets of phenomenology and hermeneutics, and failing to penetrate their deep underlying principles, theories and insights which have become a major influence in almost all 20th century intellectual thought, profoundly shaping modern philosophy and impacting such diverse disciplines as computer science, history, archaeology, physics, mathematics, logic and linguistics, the convener has reduced the discussion of phenomenology and hermeneutics to the most simplistic clichés. Such minimalistic treatment has greatly distorted the real essence of phenomenology and hermeneutics, resulting in an over-simplistic view that has no valid philosophical framework or methodological orientation. Without such framework and orientation, the research approaches presented in this seminar have no theoretical grounding, and therefore, no practical justification. Without the constraints of theory and practical justification, the imagination is free to conjure up whatever “approach” or “technique” seems easiest or most expedient to the researcher, hence the origination of such an esoteric approach as Moustakas' heuristic. Not only is there no justification for the approaches presented in this seminar, as will be demonstrated in the following section, but such a minimalistic presentation greatly distorts the depth and breadth of hermeneutics and phenomenology. As a sample of this depth and breadth, I have included an appendix of randomly accessed material that depicts some of the areas and concerns which phenomenology and hermeneutics have addressed, and some of the concepts that have been central to a very wide expanse of intellectual endeavor.

REFLECTIONS

At the opening of the seminar, the convener did not introduce himself, did not solicit individual introductions from the participants, and without any background, orientation or stated purpose or viewpoint, asked everyone to write a short narrative of how they had arrived there. Without knowing what information was being solicited, or what viewpoint was of concern, whether it be logistical, emotive, reflective/historical, or whatever, the exercise was of course, pointless. The seminar went downhill from that point on. The convener was listless and unenergetic throughout. Speaking in a dronelike monotone not much above a mumble, his manner was unenthusiastic and lacked any spark of vibrancy, authority, inspiration or passion. This was my first (and hopefully only) experience in encountering a convener or speaker for any event whose level of animation was not much more than that of a damp washcloth. It felt to me that to the convener the whole thing (the seminar, that is) was an onerous task that had to be endured and gotten through with the least amount of effort expended. There was no direction or control; discussions and dialog went all over the place without any attempt on the part of the convener to bring content back

into focus or redirect discussion to the topic at hand. Off-the-wall questions were not only answered by the convener (you can well imagine the kind of answer that was returned by the convener), but expounded upon *ad absurdum*!! In fact, the entire seminar seemed rambling, totally unstructured, unfocused and ill-prepared.

From the onset, it was apparent to me that no one besides myself had done the readings, a fact that was confirmed in private talks with the individual participants. As a doctoral-level seminar, one must expect, at the very least, that the preparatory material be well engaged by all the participants in order to have not only a meaningful, but at the doctoral level, a scholarly dialog. I personally take my doctoral work very seriously. Any compromise on program integrity is a negative reflection on the value of my work and my degree. I view the Ph.D as the highest academic achievement from an institutionalized program of study. I view it as a scholarly pursuit reflecting a dedicated commitment to academic rigor. If the seminars are treated by The Union Institute as mere fluff to simply acquire the requisite number of residency days to fulfill accreditation requirements, then I would challenge the legitimacy of The Union Institute program. If, on the other hand, the seminars are regarded as serious scholarly endeavors, there is no excuse for coming to a seminar unprepared, neither on the part of the convener nor on the part of the participant. Anyone unprepared should not be allowed to attend, or not be given credit for the seminar. If such regulations are not enforced, then the seminar program is a sham and The Union Institute Ph.D degree is flawed, if not worthless.

In my two other Union Institute seminars, the situation was dramatically different. Both featured rich, scholarly content with highly involved and focussed participants, demonstrating a preparation that evidenced significant engagement with the reading assignments. In one of the seminars, a paper had to be submitted prior to attendance in order to receive credit for the seminar. This helped ensure the requisite level of engagement with the materials. In these two other seminars, the dialog, discussions, and questions from the participants were focussed, topically orientated, and evidenced knowledge and thoughtful consideration of the issues borne out in the corpus. The conveners were thoroughly versed in the seminar subject, were animated, enthusiastic, and vibrant lecturers and gave comprehensive, detailed, highly logical and organized articulate and interesting presentations. For me, what made these seminars worthwhile, was not only how well-prepared and organized they were, and the enthusiasm and expertise of the conveners, but also, they presented all sides of the subject, including those arguments that addressed the very legitimacy of many of the main tenets of the subject itself. The result was a stimulating debate on the issues and a balanced view of the subject matter (Sharpe 1997; Sigman 1996).

Getting back to the present seminar under review, I labored to some extent in the first section of this paper to expose some deadly flaws in the concepts and underlying issues of the subject matter of this seminar as presented in the syllabus, reading list and related materials. The problems cited in those materials were manifestly evident in the actual presentation. Indeed, the presentation confirmed for me that the convener did not have a clear grasp of the material that he had included in the reading list.

The convener discussed Dilthey's pivotal role in formulating a proposal for research methodology that would more readily lend itself to human science as opposed to the methodology employed in the natural sciences. In formulating such a proposal, Dilthey changed the meaning of hermeneutics from a discipline for interpreting an author's meaning into a general method of comprehension through which data basic for the human sciences is derived and studied, launching a dialog in the philosophy of science that was to evolve into a body of methods and techniques known as qualitative research. But, in direct contradiction to the convener's claim that Dilthey championed a less empirical approach to human science to create a more *subjective science*, Dilthey considered himself to be a "stubborn empiricist" (Bleicher 1980, 23). "Dilthey eventually turned away from the interpretation of one's own realm through introspection. He maintained that introspection is inevitably predisposed and biased. 'Only under very restricted circumstances,' he said, 'does experience remain present to inner observation.' He did not believe that the problems of introspection could be overcome . . ." (Ermarth 1978, 210). In fact, he refuted the entire notion of the scientific legitimacy of phenomenology and Moustakas' concept of heuristics. "The more carefully we examine our own experience, the more susceptible the experience becomes to our own interference, for the interference changes the experience itself. Moreover, our very use of language to describe our experience transforms the experience . . ." (Polkinghorne 1983, 222).

For instance, by describing an experience, we have transformed that experience into certain feelings and impressions that were introduced by the choice of words that were used -- such feelings and impressions may or may not have been constituted in the original experience, or may represent a subtle change in the original impression that belies the nature of the actual experience. In phenomenology, the researcher attempts to "get inside the head" of the subject, using epoché to suspend all presupposition, allowing a pure, clear picture of the subject's experience from the subject's inner world. Such an approach is totally naive and impossible. We cannot suspend all we know to view another's experience from their worldview — in fact, we can never completely understand another person's worldview, or even our own — everything we see, feel, and do, our basic language, style and manner of communication, processing of

information — everything — is an indivisible constituent of our worldview, which is the absolute essence of our very existence as sentient human beings (for a discussion on the nature of knowledge and understanding, see Robinson 1997).

Much of that worldview, and indeed, personality itself, is hardwired, based on our own unique disposition of the mechanisms of vision, hearing, smell, touch and all other sense organs; physiological functioning; neuronal activity; and all other physical and biological properties that affect to what extent we are able to perceive various stimuli; how such stimuli is processed and internalized into levels of awareness; and intellectual proclivities; that, together, make each of us unique in our abilities, motivations, desires, styles of communication, emotional responsiveness, etc. Our essence is composed of worldview-phenotype-personality with a constant interaction with the environment in an ongoing dynamic that modifies our worldview moment to moment at a microsubstratum below the level of awareness.

The billions of sensory inputs that are constantly being processed into patterns of information by the brain to form impressions and build logical constructs, mental images and schemas and personal knowledge databases, are so vast and complex, that they swamp and totally overwhelm the conscious mind. If such microsubstratum activities were conscious, all concentration would be totally absorbed in analyzing how each microstimulus is processed and internalized — and we would starve to death dwelling on the sensations and impressions of being hungry rather than forming a broad perception of the world that would enable our interaction with that world to obtain nourishment. Much of worldview then, is physical/biological, and much is unknowable. Although we pride ourselves on our scientific, intellectual, and technological accomplishments, much of human functioning and understanding is noncerebral, subconscious, or automatic.

The problem that science has with phenomenology, and most of psychotherapy, is that such orientations primarily fail to recognize the physical/biological component of experience and worldview and admit the degree to which the underlying patterns or essence of particular conscious thoughts and conscious perception is simply unknowable. By attempting to explain human experience and conscious behavior while denying major components of that experience and ignoring the fact that much of what is being investigated is simply unknowable, phenomenology (and Moustakas' heuristic method even more so) can only be viewed from a scientific orientation as inherently flawed and bogus (for a discussion on the prevailing definition of science and the scientific method, see Robinson 1997).

Which side of the debate one is on is irrelevant, but what the convener fails to point out, is that the methods and techniques presented in this seminar are unscientific by definition (*ibid.*), and that these techniques, and the entire field of

qualitative research, is met with degrees of resistance from the scientific community and many other sectors in academia. Whether by intention or lack of knowledge, the convener has portrayed Dilthey as legitimatizing subjective qualitative research methodology as a valid scientific endeavor, where in fact, he strongly felt the opposite. That is why he proposed hermeneutics be broadened from pure literary analysis to a method for the human sciences so that the artifacts or text of human consciousness rather than human consciousness itself was the object of study since he felt that human consciousness could never be fully known and was not a valid realm of research. He proposed to structure a hermeneutic methodology that though delved into a limited personal perspective, maintained a rigid scientific objectivity.

The hermeneutic approach was transmogrified through the philosophical concept of *verstehen* and the different ways of understanding, including nondiscursive understanding and the reaching of understanding through an initial *tacit* understanding which, through the hermeneutic circle, evolves into a more definitive comprehension until a level of acceptable *verstehen* is reached. *Tacit understanding* is later picked up by the humanistic psychologists as *tacit knowledge*, but is changed from its original meaning as a dim adumbration or nonverbal hint of some fundamental understanding that dwells just below the level of concrete articulation as a faint glimmer within our worldview, to a highly introspective focus that is defined by Polanyi as “ . . . an act of indwelling by which we gain access to new meaning. When exercising a skill we literally dwell in the innumerable muscular acts which contribute to its purpose, a purpose which constitutes their joint meaning. Therefore, all understanding is tacit knowledge, all understanding is achieved by indwelling” (Polanyi [1966] 1983, 160). But in Polanyi’s definition, we have a deadly contradiction — the act that he chooses to use as an example of indwelling, that of exercising a skill, where all the innumerable muscular acts specific to that skill work in a precise learned relationship are focused upon at a deep, tacit level of awareness, the activity of the individual muscles that constitute the exercise of that skill is actually entirely nonconscious and unknown to our conscious state — it is the fully aware, gross muscular acts of purposefulness, like the application of just the right pressure and the positioning of the paintbrush at a prescribed angle to the canvas and the movement of the brush across the canvas as we draw that we focus on, not the activities of all the individual muscles in the fingers, hands, arms, shoulders, back and wherever else that constitutes a specific mechanical movement. In contrast to the nonconscious learned individual muscular activity constituting the exercise of a particular skill, indwelling, the major technique in humanistic psychology and of Moustakas’ heuristics, is a *purposeful conscious introspective focus*! Equally problematic, there is absolutely no logical relationship whatsoever between a skill and the presumed focus on its underlying constituent muscular activity, and the conclusion that all understanding is tacit understanding! The conclusion is a complete non sequitur.

But be that as it may, whatever logical faults there may be in the literature, I at least wanted to resolve the contradictions between the literature and the presentation. Not wishing to openly challenge or confront the convener, I waited until a break and approached the convener privately about the discrepancies between his presentation and the literature. Having brought several sources from the reading list and related materials with me, I showed him the source of the above citation concerning Dilthy's empirical orientation. He acted like it was some sort of incomprehensible artifact from the deepest reaches of the uncharted realms of the cosmos. He refused to engage me in a discussion on that topic or any other. Every time I tried to talk with him about the material, I was met by a blank, vacuous stare and a lot of "harrumph, uh hmmm" and clearing of the throat, but never an intelligent response of any kind! The only possible conclusion that I could draw from this reaction, was that he was simply either not very well acquainted with the subject matter, or was not able to fully digest and understand the material, or some combination thereof.

I am not nitpicking, as there were severe flaws in the presentation throughout the seminar and each time I tried to engage the convener in an intellectual discussion or even a simple clarification, I was met with the same vacuous look and lack of response. When the convener was introducing the topic of *intentionality* I asked him to please explain the difference between *intentionality* and the concept *intensionality* as presented by Husserl, Heidegger, R. D. Laing and other philosophical phenomenologists and existentialists, and how *intensionality*, a fundamental component of an individual experiential frame of reference, was deemphasized, or ignored as the technique of phenomenological reduction evolved in phenomenological psychology directly from the Husserl tradition. The convener responded that the term *intensionality* was not known to him, confirming my suspicion of his particularly narrow engagement with the corpus.

The technique *imaginative variation* was portrayed in this seminar as a process by which an experience is described by a subject and broken down by the researcher into specific invariant themes or components which are then each envisioned in different imaginative settings by the researcher, revealing deeper, enhanced and expanded insights on each of those themes that together constitute the essence of the experience under investigation. However, at least historically, and in phenomenological psychology, the literature defines *imaginative variation* entirely differently. Husserl was the first to define a technique referred to as *free imaginative variation*.

After the researcher has identified his own 'original phenomenon' or other examples of the phenomenon, these examples are submitted to a series of 'free imaginative variations.' This process is comparable to what contemporary Anglo-American

philosophers call the method of ‘counterexamples.’ In this process, the example is described, and then the description is transformed — possibly, by adding a predicate or deleting one of the predicates contained in the description. Using the example of the *eidos* ‘ball,’ the predicate ‘round’ would be deleted as an invariant structure, since nonround balls such as footballs exist. With each addition or deletion, the researcher questions whether the amended description still describes an example of the same kind of object or phenomenon as that which the original example was said to exemplify. Sometimes when a predicate is added or deleted from the description, what remains is a description of a different kind of phenomenon from the original. At other times, the additions and deletions do not affect the essential features of the kind of phenomenon exemplified by the different examples. Through this process of mental experimentation, the necessary and invariant features, the identical core of meaning or essence of the original phenomenon, become apparent and can be distinguished from features that are accidental and hence irrelevant to the eidetic description. (Polkinghorne 1983, 44)

Husserl proposed two basic approaches to the study of human experience. One, the method of free variation, leads to the description of invariant or essential structures. . . In the first method, the free variation leads — [as an example] — to a description of the structure of the essence of ‘appleness’ — that is, it disengages the idea of apples from all accidental aspects manifested in a particular apple. A particular apple may be red, but redness is not part of the essence of ‘appleness,’ for there are also yellow and green apples. The structure of ‘appleness’ includes a particular skin texture, seeds, stem, and so on. However, the search for essential structures differs from the process through which biologists establish taxonomic categories based on anatomical similarities. According to Husserl, the structures of experience are the organizing principles making sense of experience in the first place; the ‘facts’ (this particular apple is green and is three inches in diameter, etc.) presuppose the *eidos* ‘apple.’ Thus free variation differs from induction; the latter examines actually existing cases and proposes generalizations, the former sifts out the essential features of such an experience ‘in principle’ (for any apple, real or imaginary, here before me or eaten yesterday, and so on). (ibid., 204-205)

From the foregoing, we can see that, in dramatic contradiction to the description presented in the seminar that defined *imaginative variation* as a process used to gain deeper insight into the discrete invariant themes that together comprise the essence of an experience, Husserl defined *free imaginative variation* as a process by which the actual invariant structures of the essence of an experience can be identified. Further, rather than have the researcher drift into a series of elaborate, anything-goes, freewheeling random imaginings, as actually portrayed by example in the seminar, the free variation approach defined by Husserl is a

highly methodical process that adds and deletes predicates within a description of an experience until the experience is changed, identifying all those predicates that are the fundamental constituents of the experience, and disregarding the rest.

This definition by Husserl forms the basis of imaginative variation as practiced in phenomenological psychology. "Imaginary variation is a way of asking through reflective imagination what would I have to vary (alter) about this thing in order that it would cease to be what it is? Husserl's perceptual example of color may help to clarify what imaginary variation is. We ask ourselves, can we imagine color extended in space over 10 m²? Yes we can. Can we imagine color extended in space over 10 cm²? Yes we can. Can we imagine color without extension? No, we cannot. So, we see that an essential aspect of color is that it must be extended in space. Our method of arriving at essences is to vary the parameters of a phenomenon in our imagination until we arrive at the limit case. What the reader may have noticed at this point is the 'subjective' nature of this process. It is true that imaginary variation is based upon individuals' intuitions. However, Husserl claimed that the grasping of essences is an immediate grasping (intuition) which is grasped with a certitude which lies beyond individual idiosyncrasies. Were someone to say to Husserl 'I can imagine a color without extension in space' Husserl would reply that either this person is denying his own experience of color, or he has simply not understood what 'extension' and 'space' mean. It must be stated here that essences are not inferred or deduced, they are spontaneous affirmations which partake of experiential certitude. Husserl is always speaking of the way phenomena appear to consciousness-as-such. He is likewise speaking of essences which are graspable by any consciousness. [Here] is the place where phenomenological psychology must deviate from Husserl's philosophical transcendental phenomenology. But for now suffice [*sic*] to say that all essences are grasped under the reduction by means of imaginary variation and are direct, intuitive affirmations" (Bullington and Karlsson 1984, 53-54).

In the foregoing, the process by which parameters are varied in order to arrive at the essence of an experience involves intuition, by definition an instinct that operates at the nonconscious level. It is also rigidly methodical, restricting subjective choice to each parameter which is to be varied, with the result immediate and decisive; either the experience or phenomenon has changed or it has not. This strict methodical approach is miles apart from the approach presented in the seminar which dwells totally, absolutely, in the equivocal subjective imagination, with no experiential certitude to ground it. In the approach portrayed in the seminar, the researcher, by dwelling in the imaginative realm, interjects a constituent theme or component of a subject's

experience into the researcher's own highly personal, subjective world, transforming that component into a personal perspective of the researcher's, not the subject's, which, since we are each unique individuals, is, again by definition, anywhere from subtly to significantly dissimilar to the way it was originally experienced by the subject, transforming that experience rather than defining it. Such a process is counterproductive to epoché, the process whereby the researcher strives to avoid preconceptions of phenomena to enable the experience of the subject to be understood from the subject's orientation without the distortion of the researcher's perceptions. If this usage of imaginative variation is applied, what, then, is the point of epoché (the definition of which in the seminar by the way was considerably distorted from that of the literature)? By such process we have obfuscated the actual experience that the research is trying to uncover and describe. The result being that the research method itself takes us farther away from the essence of the experience that the research purportedly seeks to discover!! An exercise in absolute absurdity.

The purpose of imaginative variation in the phenomenological approach to behavioral studies is to determine the essence of experience for an individual under defined conditions, and can only be meaningful if the essence is analyzed exclusively in the context of the subject *vis-vis* situation or personality type, etc., not, as portrayed in the seminar, from the freewheeling subjective imagination of the researcher. Giorgi further defines the use of imaginative variation in psychological research:

The third characteristic of the [phenomenological] method was the search for essences. Usually, the phenomenologist first situates himself at the universal level of analysis and then proceeds, by way of imaginative variation, to uncover the invariants of the phenomenon. A description of the invariants constitutes their essence. The procedure at the psychological level is similar, but not identical. The major difference is that what is usually sought is a level of analysis that is neither universal nor particular but general. Psychologists are more interested in essences or structures that are context related, or relevant for typical situations or typical personalities, and so on, rather than the universal as such. Nevertheless, even though stopping short of complete universality, the procedure can still claim to be phenomenological because the method of free variation is employed in obtaining the typical essence. One consequence of stopping short of universality is that the meanings arrived at are subject to change more than universal essences because the very relationship to contexts or situations that limits the range of generality introduces a dependency on contingencies that universal essences do not have. Nevertheless, this dependency is understood as a price the psychologist has to pay in order to arrive at structures that are responsive to his [*sic*] interests. Yet, the

modification introduced still stays within the phenomenological framework because free variation is employed and also because regardless of the fact that the essences are limited, they still transcend the facts upon which they are based — just as universal structures do. (Giorgi 1985a, 50)

A major problem with the Moustakas-Douglass approach to phenomenological research, as described by Patton (Patton 1990, 407) and presented in this seminar, is that it rather arbitrarily mixes concepts, techniques, methods, etc. from disparate and often mutually exclusive traditions, resulting in a loose hodgepodge of often logically incompatible steps and processes. Much of the source of this problem stems from the rather liberal appropriation of Van Manen's so-called "hermeneutic phenomenology" (Van Manen 1990). First of all, Van Manen, author of several books in education and Professor of Education at the University of Alberta, is an educator not a behavioral scientist, and rather than human science as an end, focuses on qualitative research techniques as they may be applied to pedagogical problems. In his attempt to combine two mutually exclusive approaches, phenomenology (descriptive) and hermeneutics (interpretative), into a single unified approach, he makes a deadly conceptual error. Just like oil and water, which cannot combine in solution, and apples and oranges, which are totally distinct in taste, texture and taxonomic designation, the two methods, while they can inform one another, are totally distinct in theory, practice and purpose, and cannot be combined into a single, unified approach with any justification.

In attempting to reconcile the inherent distinctions between the phenomenological and hermeneutic methods, Van Manen covers pretty much the same ground on the last paragraph on page 7 and from the last paragraph on page 24 through page 27 of his book *Researching Lived Experience* (ibid.) as I have done on pages 2-8 of this paper, whereby I demonstrate how the seminar has confused the conceptual affinities of the two methods *in philosophical terms* with a single, interchangeable method *of actual practice*, though my discussion is much more universal and extensive than that of Van Manen's, which is based on the narrow view of a pedagogical orientation. Van Manen suggests that "hermeneutic phenomenological" research is fundamentally a writing activity, but since hermeneutical and/or textual analysis has been broadened in qualitative evaluation to include such diverse source materials as video or voice recordings, conversations, artistic performances, artistic works, all kinds of written or printed materials, and in fact, any kind of human action, it is no more a fundamental writing activity than *any* kind of research, be it qualitative or quantitative, including archaeological excavation, that requires thorough documentation for review, analysis and verification. What he really means, is that, in his research paradigm, writing becomes not just the tool of

documentation, but the process of research itself. When, starting on the last paragraph on page 180 of his book, *Researching Lived Experience* (ibid.), he attempts to demonstrate the logical fabric that enables hermeneutic and phenomenological inquiry to be combined in purpose and practice to create a single, unified research methodology as he has outlined in the foregoing portions of the text, he simply bulldozes over the relationship between philosophy and practice and interpretation and description that he made earlier on.

Van Manen's research paradigm is resplendent with inconsistency and contradiction. Take for example, his emphasis on writing and the importance of language, rhetoric and semiotics as tools in a reflective process of analysis and interpretation. Van Manen talks about the creation of anecdotal narratives, how writing mediates reflection and action and how writing *is* the method. He talks about "hermeneutic interviews" and "hermeneutic conversations" and creating text that is "oriented," "strong," "rich," and "deep." It is from Van Manen that the Moustakas-Douglass approach has extrapolated such steps as "textual portrayal," "textual portrayal of the whole," "structural portrayal," "revised textual portrayal," and "creative textual-structural synthesis," all focussing on creative writing, rhetoric, and highly subjective interpretation, each time, moving the essence of experience, and the experience itself, farther and farther from its context. Van Manen states, "Writing tends to orient us away from contextual particulars toward a more universal sphere," (ibid., 128) exactly what Giorgi states the researcher in phenomenological psychology seeks to avoid!

While both Heidegger and Gadamer held the basic assumption that all human knowledge is ultimately interpretation because it stems from a historical and cultural perspective, and therefore there is a *universal hermeneutic* to all knowledge and understanding, this *universal hermeneutic* exists only as a philosophical view, and bears no relation whatsoever to research approaches. From a practical research side, such terms as "hermeneutic interview" and "hermeneutic conversations" are oxymorons — ludicrous self-contradictions — since the interview, or the conversation (each a basic phenomenological method), is designed to hear and describe the nuances and "voice" of the subject in the subject's own words and expressions, and through phenomenological reduction and epoché, *without researcher bias or interpretation*, derive from those words and expressions the essences of the experience.

In contrast, hermeneutical inquiry or interpretation is an analytical approach using a number of specific analytical techniques to derive underlying meaning, rather than defining experience per se, from the source "text" (whether it be written material, conversation, dance or some other human action), relative to a defined context. And while both approaches may be used on a single subject or data set to gain a richer, more detailed view of an experience, they remain

entirely distinct approaches with entirely distinct techniques and objectives. While conceptual affinities exist and some techniques, such as epoché, may be used in both approaches, the approaches as whole research paradigms, remain mutually exclusive.

Though Ricoeur states that hermeneutics and phenomenology share the thesis that the source of meaning is anterior to language, the Van Manen approach, and by emulation, the Moustakas-Douglass approach, instead of looking beneath the rhetoric and bracketing it off to define deep, underlying meaning or pure experiential essence, foster additional layers of rhetoric beyond the subject's, focusing almost exclusively on language and the creative exposition of the researcher. The Van Manen/Moustakas-Douglass approach, by combining elements of hermeneutics and phenomenology into a single, unified approach replete with internal cross-purposes and contradictory rationales, is self-defeating; the conflicting paradigms cancelling each other out. It is a hodgepodge of this and that with no cohesive logical framework. "Hermeneutic phenomenology" is neither hermeneutic nor phenomenological, it dramatically deviates from mainstream qualitative research paradigms, it has no fundamental basis of rationale, and it is inherently antithetical to psychological evaluation in general and phenomenological psychology in particular. Since Van Manen is not a psychologist, and is concerned with research only in a pedagogical context, this last point is not particularly damning for his purposes, but for practicing psychologists Moustakas and Douglass, whose area of work most definitely *is* psychology, this is utterly incomprehensible.

Again, as with the Moustakas "heuristics," it is the greatest of disservice to unsuspecting students to pass off a research paradigm as a recognized, generally accepted approach in the academic and research communities, when it is a highly esoteric fabrication that has no acceptance or following outside its own small, self-serving circle. This is not honest scholarship or dialog. It is pure ruse. If one wants to explain and teach her/his own method or approach to research, that is perfectly fine and acceptable, but such a tutorial must be grounded in a full understanding of the standard paradigms as a base with which the departure can be compared and evaluated, and, most importantly, it must be clearly stated and emphasized that such departure is an esoteric approach not recognized in the mainstream of qualitative research.

Most disturbing of all, no framework for a research study was provided at all in the seminar. How is a research study actually structured? How are problems formulated into explicit research questions from which a research design can be defined, and how are subjects identified and found? What is the relationship between data types, data gathering methods, and data analysis techniques? How

are research results substantiated as viable or reasonable? None of these very fundamental questions were ever addressed in the seminar. How can it make any sense at all to talk about research approaches without a foundation on what types of problems are being addressed, what type of data is required, and how can results be demonstrated to address specific problems in a nonarbitrary way that is meaningful? What are the pros and cons of various methods and techniques? For which situations are they best suited or ill-suited? None of these absolutely essential questions was even minimally considered in the seminar. This seminar had no viable content -- it was all smoke and mirrors; all fluff covering a dubious research approach that has no grounding in basic research fundamentals.

I would like to end with a quick comment concerning the overall quality of the presentation itself, irrespective of the problems with the actual content. In dramatic contrast with Dr. Sigman's seminar on qualitative research (Sigman 1996), which featured detailed, fully defined case studies, exercises definitively broken down into different stages of a research study, and detailed examples of techniques and dialogs that contained complete problem descriptions, protocols, and intact text for textual analysis to provide the entire framework of a research problem, from formulating the problem, defining the subject and the nature of the data required for study, developing a plan and method for data gathering, devising the analytical techniques and procedures and determining the style of the research narrative, the seminar under review had no prepared materials.

In Dr. Sigman's seminar, the presentation and materials were detailed, explicit, and focussed, and the format was highly organized and structured — even to the point of requesting participants to bring scissors and a tape recorder to the seminar, both items essential for exercises in “cut-and-paste” data analysis and phenomenological interviewing. Well planned and prepared, with explicit exercises, much of the learning and exposure to concepts, techniques, and methods in Dr. Sigman's seminar was through highly effective “hands-on” participation. In contrast, the group break-away sessions in the seminar under review were totally unfocused and unstructured. The “exercises,” without explicit materials, degenerated into “touchie-feelie” babble *sans* content, data, and purpose. The group sessions in the seminar under review were sheer chaos, composed of individuals without a clue about research — especially qualitative research — without any familiarity or engagement with the reading list whatsoever, and with no prepared exercises for guidance, and absolutely no concept of a research framework, which was never provided in the seminar presentation; it was simply “the blind leading the blind.” Dialog and discussion,

both within the group, and in the full gathering, was a pathetic jumble of nonsense, often having no bearing on any topic of relevance to the seminar subject. It was a sad and highly disturbing indictment of what was supposed to be a dignified, intellectual engagement of an academic topic at the doctoral level. The seminar was a complete farce under any criteria.

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